GLASSHOUSE

HIS MASTER'S VOICE?

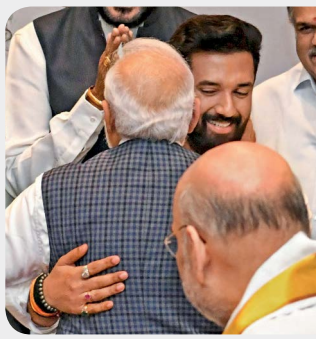
Ajit Pawar's chief ministerial ambitions have always been an open secret, so much so that after joining the alliance government in Maharashtra, he had joked that he'd already been deputy CM five times, so it was perhaps time to get a promotion. Rumours that he may soon replace Eknath Shinde at the helm have gathered steam of late. The gossip mills went on overdrive on July 22 after Pawar confidant and MLC Amol Mitkari's birthday wishes tweet for his boss: "I Ajit Anantrao Pawar take oath as the chief minister of Maharashtra...! Soon #AjitParva". Mitkari has since claimed he was merely reflecting the wishes of Pawar's supporters in the NCP. The other deputy CM and BJP leader Devendra Fadnavis too stressed—for the umpteenth time—that Shinde will not step down. The whispers, though, refuse to die down.



Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

Mind the Feet

Though **Chirag Paswan** paid his respects and touched the feet of estranged uncle Pashupati Kumar Paras at the dinner hosted for NDA parties in Delhi on July 18, the warmth was short-lived. Both have staked claim to the Hajipur LS seat and also indicated that not much should be read into the "courtesy" exchange. Political observers agree, pointing to how Chirag had touched Nitish Kumar's feet at a function last year but has continued with his vitriolic attacks against the Bihar CM. Moral of the story being that touching the feet of one's elders means little in politics. But then Chirag also greeted PM Modi at the NDA dinner, and touched his feet too!



SCHOOL IS OUT

The Bharat Rashtra Samithi regime in Telangana has 'banned' private donations of any kind to the poorly equipped state-run schools. It seems images of children without books and classrooms without furniture—used by rival party leaders while announcing grants—had become a source of embarrassment ahead of the assembly poll. Except that the ban comes after what critics call the "3G [3-generation] effect". CM K. Chandrashekar Rao's grandson and industries minister K.T. Rama Rao's son, **Himanshu Rao K.**, turned 18 on July 12, and the occasion saw donations (and photo-ops) for the renovation of a government school on Hyderabad's outskirts.



A Steady Comeback



Former Gujarat home minister **Gordhan Zadafia's** rehabilitation continues in the BJP with his appointment as 2024 poll in-charge for central Gujarat. A protégé of ex-CM Keshubhai Patel, Zadafia was once a bitter Modi critic, even orchestrating a rebellion ahead of the 2012 state polls. But it came to naught and he returned to the party in 2014. Since then, he has kept a low profile, but got back into the game after getting charge of the Gaurav Yatra before the 2022 Gujarat poll. Zadafia's 'return' is striking, especially since he had taken on NaMo at one point. For partymen, it brings back memories of another Hindutva strongman, Sanjay Joshi, who was forced into political oblivion.

HEALING TOUCH

The monsoons have gained strength over Kerala, the ideal time for elephants (domestic) and people alike to undergo the 'Karkadaka chikilsa', a demanding Ayurvedic regimen peculiar to the season. This year, Congress leader and 'disqualified' Wayanad MP **Rahul Gandhi** is also here at the Arya Vaidya Sala Kottakkal in Malappuram district for a seven-day session. After attending party leader and ex-CM Oommen Chandy's funeral in Puthupally on July 20, Rahul travelled to Kottakkal, where reportedly AICC general secretary K.C. Venugopal joined him. Wisdom has it that the *chikilsa* (treatment) keeps one's spirits and health in fine fettle for the rest of the year. With a gruelling poll season ahead, the Congressmen will need it.



—by Dhaval Kulkarni, Jeemon Jacob, Amitabh Srivastava, Amarnath K. Menon and Jumana Shah